



△ Planets

A planet is a near-spherical object that orbits a star. It can be rocky or gaseous but does not generate energy by nuclear fusion. This one is Mars in our own Solar System.



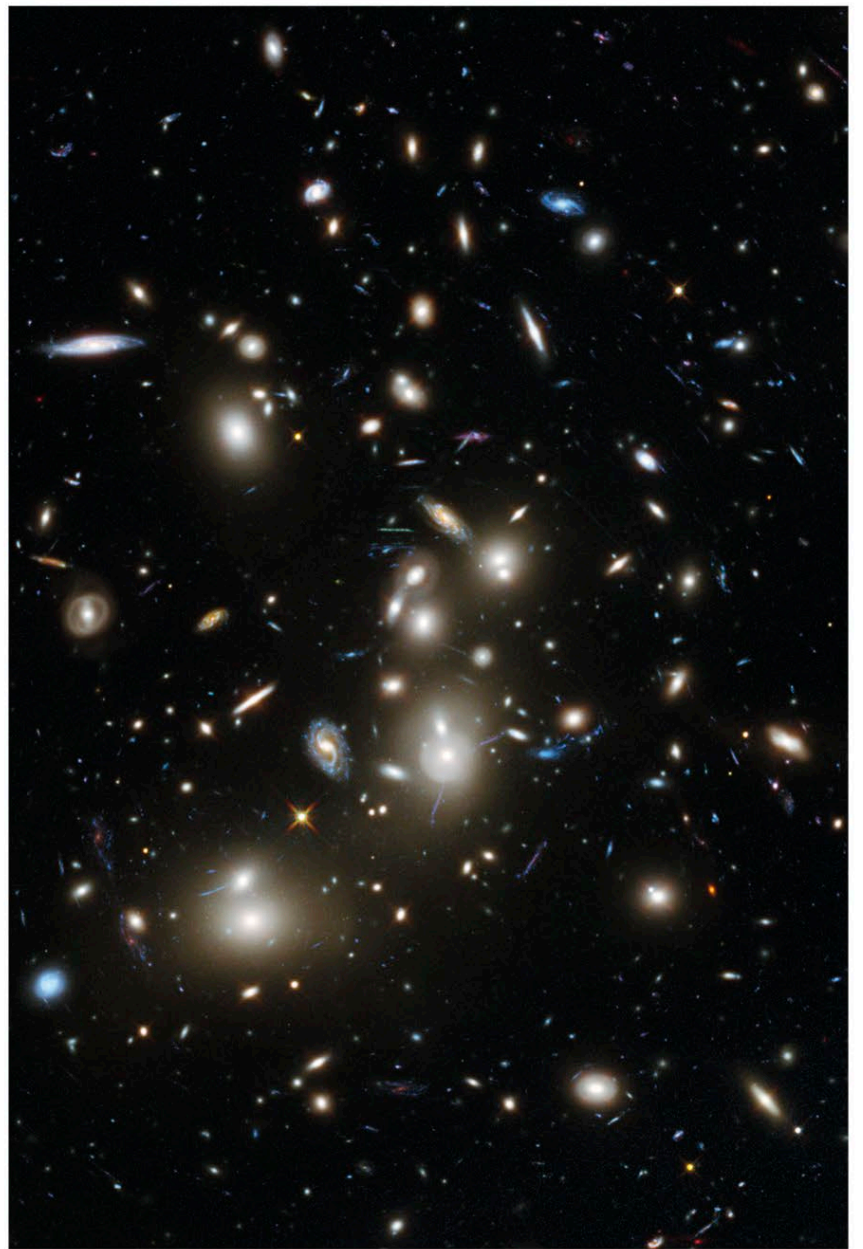
△ Moons

A moon is any naturally occurring object orbiting a planet or other body. Hundreds of moons have been identified in the Solar System, including this satellite of Saturn, Mimas.



◁ Galaxies

A collection of stars, gas, dust, nebulae, star remnants, planets, and smaller bodies is called a galaxy. Four main types exist—spiral, barred spiral, elliptical, and irregular—the example shown here being a spiral. Called NGC908, it is known to be spawning new stars at a frantic rate.



△ Galaxy cluster

Galaxies are grouped into clusters, which are themselves gathered into larger aggregations called superclusters. This galaxy cluster, Abell 2744, contains hundreds of galaxies. The whole cluster is known to be immersed in a vast sea of a mysterious, invisible material called dark matter (see pp.74–75).